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Culture (OWC): [Mossi \(FA28\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1954-1956

Coverage Date: 1954-1956

Place Coverage: Burkina Faso

Section Title(S)

JOKING AMONG THE MOSSI • Mossi Joking • THE STRUCTURAL CONTEXT OF JOKING

Such an analysis is insightful but inadequate. The social structural sources of the need for reliance on joking and the social and psychological processes which joking involves are more complex than Radcliffe-Brown recognized. More occurs in joking than the symbolic reification of "separateness" and the concurrent assertion of intergroup amity.

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THE STRUCTURAL CONTEXT OF JOKING

In support of this contention I would like first to consider the characteristics of the structural contexts in which joking tends to be institutionalized. For it is from the nature of certain social structural situations that joking derives its reason for being.

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I suggest that wherever joking is institutionalized, the relations between the participants will tend to be characterized by five interrelated factors:

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- (1) *separation*: either social or spatial or both;
- (2) *reciprocity*: a traditionally sanctioned exchange of economic social, or ceremonial goods and/or services;
- (3) *ambivalence*: an equivocal melange of amity and hostility;
- (4) *equality*: analogous individual or group status;
- (5) *independence*: the absence of relevant allegiance to a single authority.

Obviously the comparative weight of these several factors will vary with the relationships of which they are a part. Where, for example, spatial separation is great, and/or the reciprocal tie is weak, joking is likely to be mild. Where ambivalence is strong, joking may be relied on more frequently and may be more hostile in content. Where the status of the participants is unequal, joking may tend to be asymmetrical. And so on.

I further suggest that as an adjustive mechanism joking derives its significance from the manner in which it provides concurrently for the operation of three interrelated but analytically separable processes: communication, control, and catharsis. These will be considered later.

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JOKING AMONG THE MOSSI

The points in the argument just outlined may be illustrated by a brief discussion of the varieties of joking found among the Mossi living in Yatenga, an indigenous kingdom in the Voltaic Republic of West Africa. Among the Mossi, joking is institutionalized as an adjustive mechanism in the following relationships: (1) between Ego and his mother's agnatic kin, particularly his mother's elder brother; (2) between Ego and his mother's brother's wife; (3) between siblings-in-law; (4) between sibs; (5) between age-sets in the same age-grade; (6) between certain villages; and (7) between  261 the Mossi and several other ethnic groups. In each instance the structural relationship in which joking occurs is characterized by the five features listed above.

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